Background

Nelson was always handy and creative making the seemingly impossible possible. In his early years he would build custom Harley motorcycles with the long forks and high handle bars. He was an expert at making the baddest looking bikes and was sought after by all the bikers. To make the bikes look even better he got into custom painting the gas tanks and fenders. His work made the cover of biker magazines, however, this life had its dangers and he was happy to leave it behind: "Lucky for me that I got married and moved out west to Las Vegas. Most of my biker friends are no longer around."

Nelson then began a career in construction work for a local builder. About 18 years ago he met Dale Nish during a demonstration. He was fascinated with the work and later took a woodturning class with Rex Birmingham at Craft Supply in Provo, Utah. For several years he continued to take classes with the likes of Mike Mahoney and Stewart Mortimer. He found that he enjoyed the beauty and feel of the wood.

Inspirations and influences

Nelson has always found the Utah Woodturners Symposium to be a great source of inspiration. "I have been to the Utah Woodturners Symposium 18 times and every time it is a joy to meet the gifted woodworkers and see the new creations. When I saw the segmented work of Ray Allen, I knew what direction I wanted to go in. I love what I do and it keeps me going despite my age and physical ailments." Both Ray Allen and Dale Nish have influenced his turning work.

Dealing with emotional issues has been a source of creativity out of necessity. A divorce put Nelson in a depressed state that inspired the piece 'Lifesaver'. He made 'Lifesaver' after a friend asked if he had ever thought of doing a design like the traditional Native American 'feather plate'. "This got me thinking and evolved into a beautiful work of art." About six years ago when Nelson found out he has macular degeneration in his eyes it inspired him to make the abstract piece 'Faces', which has a focus point on the eyes.

Designs and ideas also come to Nelson in random ways. "Three years ago I was giving a lesson to a young man who asked if he could make a bangle for his girlfriend out of wood. I told him I didn't see why not. It proved to be quite a challenge. Since then I have created a system using Forstner bits and custom jigs to make the process simple enough for novices to make a beautiful piece that is attractive to wear." Nelson is constantly coming up with different designs and uses of wood to enhance his unique bangles with colour and movement.

MAIN PIC AND ABOVE:
Variations of the 'Feather Plate'

WT_289_65_69_PROFILE_NELSON_MBJRNC.indd 66 06/01/2016 11:40